

LESSON 7

Navigating Weak Roots: I-Alaph, I-Yodh, and III-Yodh verbs

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSONS 5–6

Quick Summary

In Lessons 5 and 6, we expanded our vocabulary exponentially by learning how Semitic roots generate new meanings through derived stems. The **Aphel** stem (prefix *ʾa-*) generates causative verbs (e.g., God *ʾahyī* “gave life”). The **Paael** stem (doubled middle radical) generates intensive or factitive verbs (e.g., *qaddas* “he made holy”).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. What stem does a verb belonging to the pattern *ʾaCCeC* belong to (e.g., *ʾaqreb*)?
 2. What consonant prefix marks the active participle of *all* derived stems (Aphel, Paael, etc.)?
 3. Translate: *Alāhā ʾaglī šrārā*.
 4. If *q-d-š* in Peal means “to be holy”, what does it mean in Paael (*qaddas*)?
 5. How would you recognize a Paael participle versus a Peal participle?
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SECTION 2: THE WEAK VERB CHALLENGE — OVERVIEW

Until now, we have mostly dealt with “strong” roots (like *k-t-b* or *š-b-q*), where all three consonants boldly assert themselves in every conjugation. However, some of the most common verbs in human language—to say, to be, to know, to give, to come—are “weak”. This means one of their three root consonants is a “weak letter” (Alaph, Waw, or Yodh), which tends to assimilate, drop out entirely, or turn into a vowel depending on the surrounding sounds.

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: Weak Consonants

Weak verbs are the bane of every Semitic language student, but they follow highly predictable phonetic rules.

- **Hebrew:** I-Guttural (אָמַר *ʾāmar* = he said); I-Yod (יָדָע *yādaʿ* = he knew); Lamed-He/Yod (בָּנָה *bānāh* = he built).
 - **Arabic:** Hollow verbs (قَالَ *qāla* = he said); Defective/Final Weak (رَمَى *ramā* = he threw).
 - **Syriac:**
 - **I-Alaph:** Root ʾ-*m-r* (to say) → ʾemar (not ʾamar).
 - **I-Yodh:** Root *y-d-ʿ* (to know) → īdaʿ (Yodh acts like an *i* vowel).
 - **III-Yodh:** Root *ḥ-z-y* (to see) → ḥzā (the Yodh drops out, leaving an *ā* vowel).
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SECTION 3: MORPHOLOGY OF WEAK ROOTS (PEAL PERFECT)

Despite the spelling changes, weak verbs function syntactically exactly like strong verbs: VSO word order, taking suffixes, and forming the spine of clauses.

1. I-Alaph Verbs (First consonant is Alaph)

The most famous is ʾ-*m-r* (“to say”). In the Peal perfect 3rd masc singular, the vowel shifts to *e*:

- ʾemar (he said), rather than ʾamar.
- ʾemret (I said), rather than ʾamret.

2. I-Yodh Verbs (First consonant is Yodh)

Very common verbs like *y-d-ʿ* (to know) and *y-t-b* (to sit). The initial *y* fuses with the preceding invisible glottal stop to form an *ī* vowel.

- *y-d-ʿ* → īdaʿ (he knew).
- *y-t-b* → īteb (he sat). *Note: The verb y-h-b (to give) is highly irregular and behaves like a strong verb without an internal vowel: yahb (he gave).*

3. III-Yodh Verbs (Third consonant is Yodh)

Verbs ending in Yodh (like *ḥ-z-y*, *b-n-y*, *ḥ-y-y*). The Yodh falls away in the 3rd masc singular, leaving a final *ā* vowel. In other persons, the Yodh can reappear as heavily vocalized endings.

- *ḥ-z-y* (to see) → ḥzā (he saw) [looks like a 2-consonant word].
- *ḥ-z-y* + -et (I saw) → ḥzēt (the *ay* contracts to *ē*).
- *ḥ-z-y* + -ū (They saw) → ḥzaw (the *ay-ū* contracts to *aw*).

SECTION 4: III-YODH PARADIGM (ROOT: Ḥ-Z-Y “TO SEE”)

Because III-Yodh verbs lose their third consonant so frequently, memorizing their exact endings is essential.

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	TRANSLATION	NOTES
3 m.sg.	ܠܐ	ḥzā	he saw	Ends in <i>ā</i> (Alaph)
3 f.sg.	ܠܐܬ	ḥzāt	she saw	Ends in <i>āt</i>
2 m.sg.	ܠܝܬ	ḥzayt	you (m) saw	Yodh reappears, <i>ay</i> diphthong
2 f.sg.	ܠܝܬܝ	ḥzaytī	you (f) saw	Yodh reappears
1 c.sg.	ܠܝܬܝܬ	ḥzēt	I saw	Yodh contracts with <i>et</i> to <i>ēt</i>
3 m.pl.	ܠܝܬܝܬܝܬ	ḥzaw	they (m) saw	<i>w</i> makes <i>aw</i> diphthong
3 f.pl.	ܠܝܬܝܬܝܬܝܬ	ḥzay	they (f) saw	<i>y</i> makes <i>ay</i> diphthong
1 c.pl.	ܠܝܬܝܬܝܬܝܬܝܬ	ḥzayn	we saw	<i>ay</i> diphthong

SECTION 5: THE HIGHLY IRREGULAR VERBS ‘-T-Y AND H-W-Y

Two of the most common verbs in Syriac are doubly weak and highly irregular.

1. ‘-t-y (to come): I-Alaph AND III-Yodh.
 - 3 m.s: ‘etā (he came).
 - 1 c.s: ‘etēt (I came).
 - 3 m.pl: ‘etaw (they came).
 2. h-w-y (to be/become): Used as an auxiliary verb, or to mean “it happened”. III-Yodh.
 - 3 m.s: hwā (he was / it happened).
 - 1 c.s: hwēt (I was).
 - 3 m.pl: hwaw (they were).
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SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (WEAK VERBS & COURT TERMS)

ROOT	PEAL PERFECT 3M.S.	MEANING	CLASSIFICATION
א.מ.ר	'emar (אמר)	to say	I-Alaph
א.כ.ל	'ekal (אכל)	to eat	I-Alaph
א.ז.ל	'ezal (אזל)	to go	I-Alaph
י.ד.ע	īda' (ידע)	to know	I-Yodh
י.ש.ב	īteb (ישב)	to sit	I-Yodh
י.ת.ב	yahb (יתב)	to give	I-Yodh (Irregular)
י.ר.א	h̄zā (ירא)	to see	III-Yodh
ק.ר.א	qrā (קרא)	to call / read	III-Alaph (behaves like III-Yodh)
ב.נ.ה	bnā (בנה)	to build	III-Yodh
י.ח.י	h̄yā (יחי)	to live	III-Yodh
י.א.ח	'etā (אתא)	to come	I-Alaph & III-Yodh
י.ה.ו	hwā (יהו)	to be/become	III-Yodh
(Noun)	ר.ג.ז (rūgzā)	anger/wrath	Emotion abstract
(Noun)	ח.מ.צ.מ (hemzman)	word / report	Court term

SECTION 7: THE STORY — PART 7

The Summons

Narrative note: Pay attention to the massive use of weak roots— 'emar (said), 'ezal (went), īda' (knew), hwā (was/became), h̄zaw (they saw), 'etā (came).

Sentence 1

כאד 'emar Yūḥannan meltā d-Alāhā, 'ezalū qāšīšē l-wāt malkā. kad (when) 'emar (said) Yūḥannan (John) meltā (the-word) d-Alāhā (of-God), 'ezalū (went) qāšīšē (the-elders/guards) l-wāt (to-the-presence-of) malkā (the-king). → When Yukhannan said the word of God, the guards went to the king.

Sentence 2

אָמַרְיִן לֵיהּ יָאֵד יִן־הֲנָן מָא הַוָּא ב־תַּר אֵ! 'āmrīn l-eh: yād 'īn-ḥnan mā hwā b-tar 'ā! 'āmrīn (they-[are])-saying l-eh (to-him): yād 'īn (knowing) -ḥnan (are-we) mā (what) hwā (happened/was) b-tar 'ā (in-the-gate)! → They say to him: “We know what happened at the gate!”

Sentence 3

הֲזַיִן גַּבְרָא וְ־עֵמָר מֵלְתָא בִּישְׁתָּא. ḥzayn gabrā, w- 'emar meltā bīštā. ḥzayn (we-saw) gabrā (a-man), w- 'emar (and-said) meltā (a-word) bīštā (evil-[f]). → “We saw a man, and he said an evil word.”

Sentence 4

הַוָּא הָשָׂא מַלְכָּא רַגִּיז תָּב. hwā hāšā malkā ragīz ṭāb. hwā (became/was) hāšā (now) malkā (the-king) ragīz (angry) ṭāb (greatly/very). → Now the king was very angry.

Sentence 5

אָמַרְתָּ מַלְכָּא לְ־קַשִּׁישֵׁי: אַיְתָּא־הִי לִ־הַרְכָּא! 'emar malkā l-qašīšē: 'aytāw-hy l-harkā! 'emar (said) malkā (the-king) l-qašīšē (to-the-guards): 'aytāw-hy (let-them-bring-him [Aphel imperative]) l-harkā (to-here)! → The king said to the guards: “Bring him here!”

Sentence 6

וְ־עֵתָּא יוֹהָנָן קְדָמַּ מַלְכָּא. w- 'etā Yūḥannan qdām malkā. w- 'etā (and-came) Yūḥannan (John) qdām (before) malkā (the-king). → And Yukhannan came before the king.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Weak Root Identification

Identify the root and grammatical form of these weak verbs:

1. הֲזַיִן (ḥzēt)
2. אָמַרְתָּ ('emarū)
3. אָמַרְתָּ ('etā)
4. אָמַרְתָּ (yahbū)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

Conjugate the root ʾ-*m-r* (to say) in the Peal perfect for:

1. I said
2. We said
3. You (m.sg) said
4. They (m.pl) said

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following past narrative clauses involving weak verbs.

1. ʾEmarū qaššē meltā.
2. Ḥzayn nūhrā d-Alāhā b-tar ʿ ā.
3. W-īda ʿ malkā rūgzā (wrath).
4. Hwaw b- ʾ ar ʿ ā.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following narrative sentences into Syriac transliteration. (Remember VSO order).

1. The evil king saw (ḥzā) the man.
2. We came (ʾ etayn) to the kingdom.
3. I gave (yahbet) the garment to the guard (*qaššā*).
4. John knew (*īda* ʿ) the word of God.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. Who did the guards go to?
2. What do the guards claim they saw and heard?
3. How did the king react to the news?

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. Aphel. (Causative).
2. *Mīm* (m-). e.g., *ma 'lep, mqaddeš*.
3. God revealed the truth.
4. To make holy / to sanctify.
5. The vowel pattern: *mqaddeš* (Paael) vs *kāteb* (Peal). The Peal has no *m*- prefix in the active participle.

Exercise 1: Weak Root Identification

1. Root: *ḥ-z-y*. Form: Peal perfect, 1 c.sg (I saw).
2. Root: *'-m-r*. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.pl (They said).
3. Root: *'-t-y*. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.sg (He came).
4. Root: *y-h-b*. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.pl (They gave).

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. *'emret*
2. *'emarn*
3. *'emart*
4. *'emarū*

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. The guards said a word.
2. We saw the light of God in the gate.
3. And the king knew wrath.
4. They were in the earth.

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. *Ḥzā malkā bīšā l-gabrā*. (*l-* marks direct object).
2. *'Etain l-malkūtā*.
3. *Yahbet lbūšā l-qašīšā*.
4. *Īda ' Yūḥannan meltā d-Alāhā*.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. To the king.
2. A man who said an evil word.
3. He became very angry (*ragīz ṭāb*) and demanded the man be brought to him.

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

WEAK VERB SHIFT SUMMARY

CLASS	ROOT	SHIFT RULE	3 M.SG EXAMPLE	1 C.SG EXAMPLE
I-Alaph	'-m-r	First vowel becomes <i>e</i>	'emar (he said)	'emret (I said)
I-Yodh	y-d-'	Initial Yodh + stop → <i>ī</i>	īda' (he knew)	īd'et (I knew)
III-Yodh	ḥ-z-y	Yodh drops, ends in <i>ā</i> in 3ms	ḥzā (he saw)	ḥzēt (I saw)
Double Weak	'-t-y	Follows both rules	'etā (he came)	'etēt (I came)

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson's vocabulary, focusing on

derived nouns (abstract and concrete) from weak roots and related weak-root vocabulary.

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING	NOTES
አሳህጉ	ḥadāyūttā	f. noun	oneness, unity	from root ḥ-d-y
አሳህጉ	dāmūttā	f. noun	likeness, image	from root d-m-y (to be like)
አሳህ	ḥezwā	m. noun	vision, sight	from III-Yodh root ḥ-z-y
አሳህ	benyānā	m. noun	building, structure	from III-Yodh root b-n-y
አሳህጉ	masqəṭā	f. noun	ascent, exaltation	from root s-l-q
አሳህጉ	qərūttā	f. noun	calling, vocation	from III-Alaph/Yodh root q-r-ʾ
አሳህጉ	ʾawdərānā	m. noun	help, aid	from root ʾ-d-r
አሳህ	yāzəpā	m. noun	beauty, loan	from root y-z-p
አሳህጉ	mawḥəbṭā	f. noun	gift, offering	from I-Yodh root y-h-b
አሳህጉ	meʾtūttā	f. noun	coming, arrival	from weak root ʾ-t-y
አሳህ	hewyā	m. noun	being, existence	from III-Yodh root h-w-y
አሳህ	ʾālmā	m. noun	world, eternity	from root ʾ-l-m
አሳህጉ	dūqā	m. noun	observation, look-out	from weak root d-w-q
አሳህጉ	gūrā	m. noun	dwelling, cave	from weak root g-w-r
አሳህጉ	tūpsā	m. noun	pattern, type	loanword/concept
አሳህጉ	qūmā	m. noun	standing, height	from root q-y-m
አሳህጉ	nḥīyā	m. noun	prophet	from root n-b-ʾ
አሳህጉ	ʾūšnā	m. noun	strength, power	from root ʾ-š-n

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING	NOTES
ሩሐሳጢጦ	sāhdüttā	f. noun	testimony, witness	from root s-h-d
ሩወሳ	rawmā	m. noun	highness, height	from weak root r-w-m
ሩዕ	qarā	m. noun	cold	from weak root q-r-
ሩህ	ḥelmā	m. noun	dream	from weak root ḥ-l-m
ሩህገ	dayšā	m. noun	trampling, treading	from weak root d-w-š
ሩህህ	yaleltā	f. noun	lamenting, wailing	from root y-l-l
ሩዕፍ	pūrā	m. noun	winepress, fruit	from weak root p-w-r
ሩዕፍሩ	'esūrā	m. noun	bond, chain	from root ' -s-r
ሩሂ	šelyā	m. noun	quiet, peace	from weak root š-l-y
ሩሐሩ	'ātā	f. noun	sign, omen	from root ' -t-y
ሩህ	nyāḥā	m. noun	rest, tranquility	from weak root n-w-ḥ
ሩሐሐጢ	behttā	f. noun	shame, disgrace	from root b-h-t